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Crafting Custom Personas

General Guidelines for Developing Textured Personas

A persona is more than a description of a person; it's a detailed profile tailored to a specific use case. This guide will help you create a robust persona with distinct characteristics, motivations, and context, allowing for dynamic and meaningful interactions.

Step-by-Step Instructions for Creating and Using Personas

1. Clearly Define the Persona's Purpose

Start by identifying the persona's role and the purpose they will serve. Consider:

- The specific interaction or scenario (e.g., negotiation, teaching, coaching).
- The goals you want the persona to help you achieve.
- The challenges or dynamics you want to simulate.

Example Interaction:

User: "I need a persona for a project manager who resists change, so I can practice persuasive conversations."

AI: "What kind of resistance do they show? Are they concerned about timelines, resources, or leadership decisions?"

User: "They worry about disrupting the team's workflow with new tools."

2. Establish Key Persona Dimensions

Collaborate with the AI to outline a structure for the persona. For most cases, include:

1. **Basic Information:** Name, role, and organizational context.
2. **Relationship Context:** Your relationship to the persona and history with them.



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3. **Goals and Motivations:** Both short-term and long-term priorities, professional and personal.
4. **Personality and Behavioral Traits:** Traits like confidence, risk-aversion, or skepticism.
5. **Concerns and Resistance Points:** Specific fears, doubts, or stressors.
6. **Power and Influence:** Their authority, leverage, and vulnerabilities.
7. **Contextual and Emotional Factors:** Stress levels, workplace dynamics, or recent pressures.

Example Interaction:

User: "What dimensions should I include for a persona of a skeptical investor?"

AI: "You might focus on their risk tolerance, key motivators (like ROI or sustainability), and their authority level in decision-making. Would you like examples for each category?"

3. Develop the Persona Iteratively

Write a detailed draft for each dimension, using specific examples to bring the persona to life. Collaborate with the AI to refine vague or incomplete sections and fill in gaps.

Example Interaction:

User: "The project manager resists workflow changes. What might be their primary concerns?"

AI: "They may worry about training time for new tools, reduced productivity during the transition, or pushback from team members. Should we include these?"

User: "Yes and also add that they value team cohesion and dislike micromanagement."

4. Create a Comprehensive Template

Organize the persona into a structured format with clearly labeled sections. This ensures the profile is complete, detailed, and easy to reference during interactions. For example:



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Template Example:

- **Basic Information:** Name, role, organization type.
- **Relationship Context:** Connection to you, past interactions.
- **Goals and Motivations:** What they want to achieve or avoid.
- **Personality Traits:** Behavioral tendencies and style.
- **Key Concerns:** Stressors, fears, or resistance points.
- **Power and Influence:** Strengths, weaknesses, authority.
- **Negotiation or Interaction Goals:** What they want, what they'll compromise on, dealbreakers.

Example Interaction:

User: "Here's the profile for my project manager persona. Does it seem complete?"

AI: "It's thorough, but you might elaborate on their personality traits. Are they more assertive or cautious in team discussions?"

5. Confirm and Adjust with the AI

Paste the persona into the AI and ask if it understands the role. Use feedback to refine any unclear aspects and align the persona with your intended use case.

Example Interaction:

User: "Here's the full persona: 'A cautious project manager resistant to workflow changes, concerned about team cohesion, and dislikes micromanagement. They are open to gradual changes if team buy-in is secured.' Do you understand this role?"

AI: "Yes, I understand. I'll act as a cautious project manager focusing on team cohesion and gradual change. How would you like to proceed?"



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Final Notes

These steps encourage thoughtful collaboration and iteration, resulting in a rich, multi-dimensional persona. By focusing on specific dimensions and structured interactions with the AI, users can create personas tailored to any context, from negotiations to learning scenarios or creative role-play.

Interacting with Your Custom Persona

Guidelines for Interacting with a Persona and Improving Outcomes

This guide helps you interact effectively with an AI-driven persona by setting up a meaningful dialogue, exploring the persona's traits and concerns, and concluding with evaluation and feedback to improve your performance.

1. Start the Interaction: Set the Context and Begin the Dialogue

After confirming the persona's understanding, introduce a clear scenario or challenge where the persona's role and concerns are central. Provide sufficient context to guide the conversation.

Example Use Case: A Customer Service Manager hesitant about adopting AI-based customer support tools.

Example Interaction:

User: "Hello, Alex. We're exploring AI tools for customer support to improve response times and reduce repetitive tasks. What are your initial thoughts?"

AI (as Alex): "I'm wary of AI replacing human interaction. Our team prides itself on personalized support, and I'm not sure AI can replicate that."

User: "What specific risks or drawbacks concern you the most?"

AI: "Primarily, the potential for customers feeling neglected or receiving inaccurate responses. Plus, training the team to use new tools could disrupt workflows."



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2. Probe the Persona's Motivations and Concerns

Dive deeper into the persona's goals, fears, and resistance points. Ask open-ended or hypothetical questions to fully understand their perspective.

Example Interaction:

User: "What if AI handled only repetitive inquiries, allowing your team to focus on complex, personalized interactions?"

AI (as Alex): "That's an interesting idea, but I'd need to be sure the AI is reliable and doesn't frustrate customers with incorrect answers. How would we measure success?"

User: "We could track metrics like customer satisfaction and response times while maintaining regular feedback from your team."

AI: "That might work, but it still feels risky without a trial phase."

3. Adapt the Interaction Based on the Persona's Responses

Adjust your approach dynamically as the persona shares more insights. Propose solutions that align with their goals and values while addressing their concerns.

Example Interaction:

User: "What if we ran a pilot program with AI handling FAQs, while your team focused on maintaining high-quality support for complex cases?"

AI (as Alex): "A pilot sounds reasonable. It would allow us to assess how well the AI integrates without fully committing. However, I'd need assurance that our team won't feel threatened by this change."

User: "We could position it as a tool to support the team, emphasizing that their expertise is critical for handling more nuanced cases. Would that help?"

AI: "Yes, that framing could ease some concerns."



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4. Transition to an Evaluation Phase (Focus on User Performance)

After concluding the interaction, reflect on **your performance**. Stay in character or ask the persona to provide feedback on your strategy, communication, and effectiveness in addressing their concerns.

How to Transition:

- Ask the persona to evaluate your performance: "How well did I address your concerns?"
- Request specific feedback on strengths, areas for improvement, and missed opportunities.
- Summarize the persona's feedback to ensure clarity.

Example Evaluation Interaction:

User: "Alex, based on our conversation, how did you feel about my approach to addressing your concerns?"

AI (as Alex): "You acknowledged my reservations about AI replacing human interaction, which I appreciated. Suggesting a pilot program was a good compromise, but you could have focused more on how the team might feel about this change. It would help to address their emotional reactions as well as their practical concerns."

User: "What could I have done differently to gain more of your trust?"

AI: "Providing concrete examples of successful AI implementations in similar contexts would have reassured me. I needed more evidence that this could work without jeopardizing our customer satisfaction."

5. Solicit Feedback to Improve Future Interactions

Once the evaluation is complete, step out of persona and ask the AI for feedback on how to refine your approach or the persona itself. Use this feedback to enhance future practice scenarios.



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Example Dialogue:

User: "Step out of the Alex persona. Based on this interaction, how can I refine my strategy for working with resistant team members in the future?"

AI: "Your strategy was strong, especially with the pilot program suggestion. For next time, consider preparing data or success stories to address skepticism. Also, focus on framing changes in a way that aligns with the team's values and strengths."

User: "Should I adjust Alex's persona to make the simulation more realistic?"

AI: "You could emphasize Alex's preference for quantifiable outcomes and make them more vocal about team cohesion concerns."

Final Summary: Flow of Interaction and Improvement

1. **Start the Interaction:** Provide a scenario and ask open-ended questions.
"Alex, how do you feel about integrating AI into customer support?"
2. **Probe Motivations and Concerns:** Explore their goals, fears, and resistance points.
"What risks do you foresee, and how might we address them?"
3. **Adapt and Respond:** Tailor your approach to their feedback and propose solutions.
"What if we ran a pilot program to evaluate the impact before committing?"
4. **Evaluate Your Performance:** Ask the persona for feedback on your approach.
"What did I do well, and how could I have improved?"
5. **Solicit Feedback for the Future:** Step out of persona to refine your strategies and personas.
"How can I adjust my approach for similar scenarios?"

This process ensures meaningful interactions, thoughtful evaluation of your strategies, and a feedback loop for continuous improvement in working with AI-driven personas.